run aground. The French fleet was only saved from destruction by the early nightfall on a dark November day. At around 5:00 p.m. firing ceased and ships anchored where they lay.

Dawn brought a renewal of the battle with the elements, but not between the fleets. Two British ships had been dragged onto a shoal and could not be saved. The French ship *Juste*, badly damaged in the fighting, was wrecked fleeing toward the Loire. Surrounded by the enemy, Conflans ran his flagship *Soleil Royal* aground and fired it to save it from falling into British hands. Seven other French ships exploited the effect of the high tide and an onshore gale to attempt to cross the usually impassable sandbar at the mouth of the Vilaine River. To do so, the sailors threw their cannon overboard to reduce their draft. Six ships made it to the shallow water beyond, thus escaping the British ships but trapping themselves in the estuary for the following year.

Hawke's victory shattered the French navy, ended the prospect of an invasion of the British Isles, and exposed French colonies and merchant shipping to the depredations of the Royal Navy for the rest of the war.

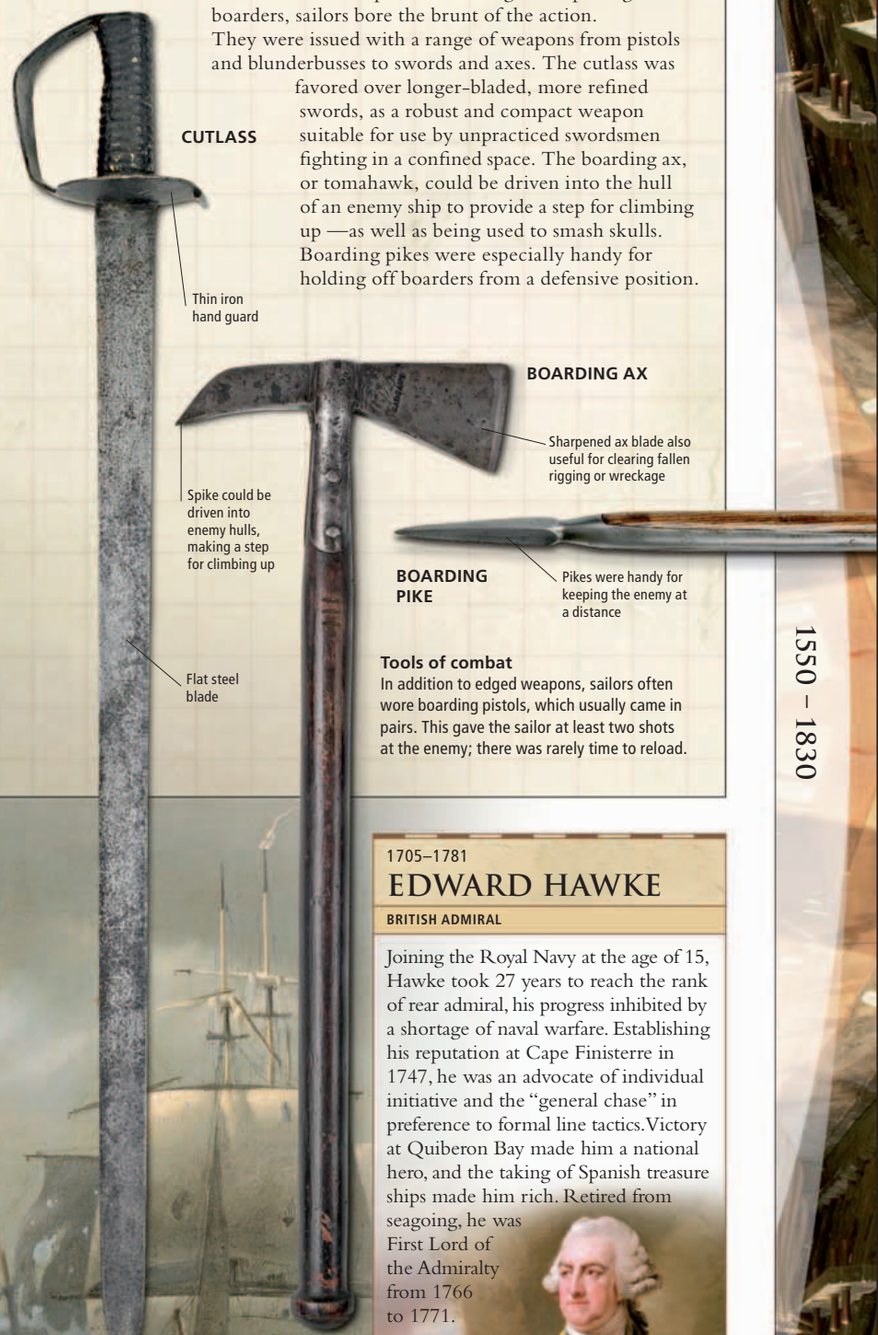
> "HAD WE BUT TWO HOURS MORE DAYLIGHT, THE WHOLE [ENEMY FLEET] HAD BEEN DESTROYED OR TAKEN."
>
> **ADMIRAL HAWKE**, DESCRIBING HIS VICTORY AT QUIBERON BAY, 1759

Decisive victory
Admiral Hawke's *Royal George* (left) is shown engaging with *Soleil Royal* (right). The latter is erroneously portrayed as a three-decker; she was in fact an 84-gun third-rater, with two decks.

WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

BOARDING WEAPONS

Despite the reign of the cannon in the age of sail, boarding was still an essential tactic, whether to seize a valuable prize or to end the resistance of a battered enemy. Either men crossed between two vessels side by side or boats were sent out with a boarding party to swarm up the hull of an enemy ship. Although musket-armed marines took part in boarding and repelling boarders, sailors bore the brunt of the action. They were issued with a range of weapons from pistols and blunderbusses to swords and axes. The cutlass was favored over longer-bladed, more refined swords, as a robust and compact weapon suitable for use by unpracticed swordsmen fighting in a confined space. The boarding ax, or tomahawk, could be driven into the hull of an enemy ship to provide a step for climbing up —as well as being used to smash skulls. Boarding pikes were especially handy for holding off boarders from a defensive position.



Tools of combat
In addition to edged weapons, sailors often wore boarding pistols, which usually came in pairs. This gave the sailor at least two shots at the enemy; there was rarely time to reload.

1705–1781

EDWARD HAWKE

BRITISH ADMIRAL

Joining the Royal Navy at the age of 15, Hawke took 27 years to reach the rank of rear admiral, his progress inhibited by a shortage of naval warfare. Establishing his reputation at Cape Finisterre in 1747, he was an advocate of individual initiative and the "general chase" in preference to formal line tactics. Victory at Quiberon Bay made him a national hero, and the taking of Spanish treasure ships made him rich. Retired from seagoing, he was First Lord of the Admiralty from 1766 to 1771.

